



Dr. Laura Taylor-Kale is the Senior Fellow for Geoeconomics and Defense at the Council on Foreign Relations. From 2023 to 2025, Dr. Taylor-Kale served as the first presidentially-appointed, senate-confirmed Assistant Secretary of Defense for Industrial Base Policy. In this role, she led all defense industrial strategy, investments, and planning, including the Defense Production Act and industrial base investments, supply chain resilience, small business programs, international defense industrial cooperation, and economic security and review of domestic mergers and acquisitions and foreign investments (CFIUS). She led the Department of Defense in developing and publishing the first-ever [National Defense Industrial Strategy and Implementation Plan](#). During her tenure, she led the expansion of strategic investments in rare earth elements, critical and strategic materials, solid rocket motors, and other upstream supply chain materials. To further accelerate investment in the Defense Industrial Base, Dr. Taylor-Kale launched [the DoD's largest other transaction contracting vehicle, the Defense Industrial Base Consortium](#). Under her leadership, the Office of Industrial Base Policy awarded a record of \$3.3 billion of grants to manufacturing and defense industrial supply chain businesses through the Defense Production Act and the Industrial Base Fund. Additionally, she established the first Board of Directors for the strategic and critical materials for the National Defense Stockpile.

Dr. Taylor-Kale has extensive experience in finance, business, economic policy and managing in complex organizations. She has served in the Department of Commerce as Deputy Assistant Secretary for manufacturing in the international trade administration in the Department of Commerce and has held positions at the World Bank and the U.S. Overseas Private Investment Corporation. Dr. Taylor-Kale began her career as a State Department Foreign Service Officer (diplomat) with postings in India, Cote D'Ivoire, Afghanistan, and the World Bank.

Dr. Taylor-Kale is the founder and CEO of Catalytic Capital Strategies LLC, an advisory firm working with venture capital firms, defense, and deep technology companies. She is also a Senior Research Fellow at the Blue Center for Strategic Assessment at the Yale Jackson School of Global Affairs. In 2018, she was a Zhi-Zhing Eisenhower fellow in China where she studied Chinese technology innovation in artificial intelligence. She holds a BA in economics from Smith College, an MPA from Princeton University, and an MBA from New York University, and a PhD in management science and engineering from Stanford University. She is a life member of the Council on Foreign Relations, a member of several private boards, and a frequent media commentator.